FORM AGENT
PRO

The Green Card Prep Checklist

Everything you'll need to gather before you file Form I-485.

A practical, no-fluff checklist of the documents most marriage-based green card filers need, plus a short guide to how the packet should be assembled, paid for, and mailed.

Not legal advice. Form Agent Pro is not a law firm and does not provide legal advice.

THE GUIDE

Before you file

A short, practical walkthrough of how to assemble and mail your green card packet. Read this once before you start gathering documents.

Filing window

Submit your packet only when every required form is signed and every supporting document is gathered. USCIS rejects incomplete packets and you lose the filing fees. There is no partial credit.

How to order the documents in your packet

USCIS doesn't publish a strict order, but a clean stack speeds intake. Use binder clips, not staples. Top to bottom:

1. **Payment.** Form G-1450 credit card authorization, one per form filed.
2. **Form I-485.** The main green card application.
3. **Form I-130.** Petition for Alien Relative, if filed concurrently.
4. **Form I-864.** Affidavit of Support, with the sponsor's tax documents attached.
5. **Form I-765** (optional). Work permit (EAD) application.
6. **Form I-131** (optional). Advance parole / travel document.
7. **Form I-693.** Medical exam, in the civil surgeon's sealed envelope. Do not open it.
8. **Supporting documents.** Birth certificate, marriage certificate, passport copy, I-94, etc.
9. **Evidence of a bona fide marriage**, if marriage-based. Clipped as a separate section.

How to pay

As of 2026, USCIS no longer accepts personal checks or money orders by mail. Pay by credit or debit card using Form G-1450, one per form filed. Place every G-1450 on top of the packet.

Filing fees change. Confirm the current amount on uscis.gov before mailing.

Where to send it

The correct USCIS lockbox depends on your state and the combination of forms you're filing. Check uscis.gov/i-485 for the current address. The wrong lockbox will delay or reject your packet.

What to expect after filing

2–4 weeks Receipt notice (Form I-797C) for each form filed.
6–10 weeks Biometrics appointment. Fingerprints and photo.
3–9 months Work permit (EAD) and advance parole approval, if filed.
8–24 months Interview, then decision. Times vary by field office.

Keep every receipt notice. You'll need them at the interview.

THE CHECKLIST

Documents to gather

Check off each item as you collect it. Originals stay with you. You mail certified copies and translations.

Identity & immigration history

- [ ] **Birth certificate (long form)**
  Required for every applicant. Attach a certified English translation if not in English.
- [ ] **Passport biographic page**
  Photocopy of the page with your photo. Required for every applicant.
- [ ] **Most recent U.S. visa**
  Photocopy of the visa stamp inside your passport. Skip if you entered visa-free or were paroled in.
- [ ] **Form I-94 arrival / departure record**
  Print the most recent record from i94.cbp.dhs.gov. Required for every applicant.
- [ ] **Two passport-style photos**
  Recent (within 30 days), 2" × 2", white background. Lightly write your name and A-number on the back.
- [ ] **Prior USCIS notices**
  Copies of any I-797 approval or receipt notices for previous immigration filings. Skip if you've never filed before.

Marriage-based filings

- [ ] **Marriage certificate**
  Certified copy of your current marriage certificate. Required if filing based on marriage.

- [ ] **Proof prior marriages ended**
  Divorce decrees or death certificates for any prior marriages, for both spouses. Skip if neither of you was previously married.
- [ ] **Evidence of a bona fide marriage**
  Joint lease or mortgage, joint bank statements, joint utility bills, joint insurance, photos together over time, affidavits. Aim for 6–10 strong items spanning your relationship.

Sponsor financial documents (for the I-864)

- [ ] **Sponsor's federal tax transcript**
  Most recent year. Order free at irs.gov. A tax return PDF is acceptable if you can't get the transcript in time.
- [ ] **Sponsor's W-2s or 1099s**
  For the same tax year as the transcript.
- [ ] **Sponsor's recent pay stubs**
  Last 6 months.
- [ ] **Employment letter**
  From the sponsor's current employer, stating job title, start date, salary, and that the position is permanent.
- [ ] **Joint sponsor documents (if needed)**
  Same set as above, from a second sponsor. Required only if the primary sponsor doesn't meet the income threshold.

Medical

- [ ] **Form I-693 medical exam**
  Completed by a USCIS-designated civil surgeon and returned to you in a sealed envelope. Do not break the seal. Valid for two years from the surgeon's signature date.

Criminal & civil history (if applicable)

- [ ] **Court records**
  Certified disposition for every arrest, citation, or charge, even if the case was dismissed, sealed, or expunged. Skip if you have no criminal history.
- [ ] **Police clearance**
  Required if you lived in certain countries for 6+ months after age 16. Check the I-485 instructions for the current list.

Travel

- [ ] **Travel history**
  A list of every trip outside the U.S. in the last five years, with dates and destinations. You'll need this for Form I-485 Part 3.

WHEN YOU'RE READY

Skip the typos. File with confidence.

Filling out USCIS forms by hand is slow and error-prone. A single typo, a wrong checkbox, or a missing signature can get your packet rejected, costing you months and the filing fees you already paid.

- → Answer questions in plain English. We fill the forms.
- → Built-in checks catch the small mistakes that trigger rejections.
- → Every form in your packet stays in sync. Change an address once and it updates everywhere.
- → Download the finished PDFs, print, sign, and mail.

When you've gathered the documents on this checklist, the rest is the easy part.

Start your filing → formagent.pro

Form Agent Pro is not a law firm and does not provide legal advice. This checklist is general guidance and may not cover every requirement for your specific case. For complex situations, consult a licensed immigration attorney.